



SW Pacific

THE ISLANDS of the southwest Pacific are home to people of many different cultures and languages. The islands are divided into three general groups based on their location and the similarities between their peoples. The Polynesian islands to the east include Tonga, Samoa, the Cook Islands, and Tahiti. Melanesia includes Fiji, the Solomon Islands, and Vanuatu. The smallest group, Micronesia, includes the Marshall, Kiribati, and Caroline Islands. The first Europeans came to the southwest Pacific in the 1600s, several thousand years after Melanesians, Micronesians, and Polynesians first arrived.

LAND OF MANY LANGUAGES

Historically, the mountainous landscape of Papua New Guinea made contact between the villages difficult. As a result of many years of isolation, some villages developed their own individual languages. Nationwide, about 800 different languages evolved.

Men in Papua New Guinea wearing traditional make-up

Beads, shells, and feathers form part of the decoration.

A MIX OF RELIGIONS

Christianity is the dominant religion on most southwest Pacific islands. However Islam and Hinduism are also practiced. Many people also retain beliefs from traditional religions that existed before the islands were colonized by people from Europe and Asia.

NORTHERN MARIANA ISLANDS
(to US)

Tinian Saipan Rota

HAGATÑA
GUAM
(to US)

ISLAND HOLIDAYS
White sandy beaches and warm water makes this region ideal for tourists.



MELEKEOK
PALAU

MICRONESIA

PALIKIR
Pohnpei

MARSHALL ISLANDS

Enewetak Atoll Bikini Atoll Rongelap Atoll

Ujialang Atoll Ratak Chain

Kwajalein Atoll Namu Atoll

Ailinglaplap Atoll

Jaluit Atoll

Ebon Atoll

Kosrae

Banaba

NAURU

SOLOMON ISLANDS

Choiseul

Malaita

Guadalcanal

San Cristobal

Rennell

Santa Cruz Islands

VANUATU

Espiritu Santo

Malekula

Maéwo

Pentecost

Ambrim

Epi

PORT-VILA

Erromango

Tanna

Aneityum

Ouvéa

Lifou

Maré

NOUMÉA

NEW CALEDONIA
(to France)

Iles Loyauté

Tropic of Capricorn

Vanuatu tribespeople dancing at a religious ceremony